

Medicinal Actions & Uses Until recently, the chief medicinal value of pomegranate was as a deworming agent, with the rind and bark being considered specific remedies for tapeworm infestation. Now, pomegranate juice is widely available and known for its positive effects on the heart and circulation. Like other medicinal plants with a high anthocyanidin content, pomegranate fruit and juice have potent protective activity on all aspects of the circulation, supporting healthy circulation and countering local inflammatory activity, which damages the inner lining of the blood vessels. The juice is commonly taken to help with cardiovascular problems, including high blood pressure, capillary fragility, angina, and congestive heart failure. It also appears to help prevent dental plaque.

Research In recent years, there has been significant interest in the medicinal properties of pomegranate fruit and juice. As above, pomegranate has a strongly beneficial activity on the cardiovascular system, but it also appears to have an unusually wide range of potential therapeutic properties, including antibacterial, antiseptic, anti-inflammatory, and estrogenic activity. James A. Duke, a former USDA botanist, has described it as an "antimenopausal fruit." Pomegranate shows signs of having anticancer activity and has been recommended as a preventative and treatment for prostate cancer. New potential uses are likely to emerge over time.

Cautions Do not use the rind or bark unless under professional supervision. This plant, and especially its bark extracts, is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Pygeum africanum (Boraginaceae) Pygeum

Description Evergreen tree growing to 115 ft (35 m). Has oblong leaves, white flowers, and red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Pygeum is native to Africa. It is still harvested from the wild, but severe shortages have led to the establishment of plantations.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Pygeum contains phytosterols (beta-sitosterol), triterpenes (ursolic and oleanolic acids), long-chain alcohols (n-tetracosanol), as well as tannins.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In conventional medicine in France, the fat-soluble extract of pygeum bark has become the primary treatment for an enlarged prostate gland. A decoction of the bark may reduce the severity of chronic prostate inflammation, and it may also help reverse male

sterility when this is due to insufficient prostate secretions. In combination with other plants, pygeum may be valuable in the treatment of prostate cancer.

Research Trials carried out since the 1960s, many of them in France, have established that pygeum extract has positive effects on the prostate gland. Specifically, the extract increases glandular secretions and reduces levels of cholesterol within the organ. In some Western countries, surgery is the main option for enlarged prostates, but in France pygeum is prescribed in 81% of cases.

Related Species The fruit kernels of the Asian *P. gardneri* are used to poison fish.

⚠ Caution Only take pygeum under professional supervision.

Quercus robur (Fagaceae) English Oak

Description Slow-growing, long-lived deciduous tree reaching 150 ft (45 m). Has deeply lobed leaves, long catkins, and green to brown fruit (acorns).

Habitat & Cultivation English oak grows throughout the northern hemisphere, in woods and forests, and along roadsides. The bark is collected in spring and the fruit is harvested in autumn.

Parts Used Bark, galls (growths produced by insects or fungi).

Constituents English oak bark contains 15–20% tannins (including phlobatannin, ellagitannins, and gallic acid). Oak galls contain about 50% tannins.

History & Folklore Sacred to the Druids, the oak tree has been esteemed in European herbal medicine for its astringent bark, leaves, and acorns.

Medicinal Actions & Uses English oak bark, prepared as a decoction, is

often used as a gargle to treat sore throats and tonsillitis. It may also be applied as a wash, lotion, or ointment to treat conditions such as

hemorrhoids, anal fissures, small burns, or other skin problems. Less commonly, a decoction of the bark is taken in small doses to treat diarrhea, dysentery, and rectal bleeding. Powdered oak bark may be sniffed to treat nasal polyps, or sprinkled on eczema to dry the affected area.

Caution Do not take oak bark internally for more than 4 weeks at a time.

Self-help Use Hemorrhoids, p. 302.



Oak bark

Quillaja saponaria (Rosaceae) Soap Bark

Description Evergreen tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has glossy oval leaves, white flowers, and star-shaped fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Soap bark is native to Chile and Peru, and is cultivated in California and India. The bark is gathered throughout the year.

Part Used Inner bark.

Constituents Soap bark contains up to 10% triterpenoid saponins, calcium oxalate, and tannins. The saponins are strongly expectorant and can cause inflammation of the digestive tract.

History & Folklore In Peru and Chile, soap bark has traditionally been used by Andean peoples as an alternative to soap. The bark has been used medicinally as an expectorant remedy.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Soap bark has a long tradition of use as a treatment for chest problems. Its strong expectorant effect is beneficial in the treatment of bronchitis, especially in the early stages of the illness. Like other medicinal plants that contain saponins, soap bark stimulates the production of a more fluid mucus in the airways, facilitating the clearing of phlegm through coughing. Soap bark is useful for treating any condition featuring congested mucus within the chest, but it should not be used for dry irritable coughs. Soap bark is also used externally, appearing in the formulations of dandruff shampoos.

⚠ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. As soap bark is irritant to the digestive tract, internal use must be carefully monitored.

Ranunculus ficaria (Ranunculaceae) Lesser Celandine, Pilewort

Description Mat-forming perennial growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has small tubers, fleshy heart-shaped leaves, and shiny-petaled, brilliant yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Lesser celandine is native to western Asia, North Africa, and Europe. Commonly found in woods, roadsides, and bare open spaces, it is collected when in flower in spring.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Lesser celandine contains saponins, protoanemonin and anemonin, tannins, and vitamin C.

History & Folklore Lesser celandine has been used from the earliest times as a medicine for the relief of hemorrhoids and ulcers. In medieval times it was believed that simply carrying lesser celandine on one's person was sufficient to cure hemorrhoids.